

Artificial Intelligence and the Amplification of Political Misinformation: Ethical Challenges in the Information Age

Mira Teague, Joshua Mark, Alexander Perez



School of Information
and Library Science

Background

Artificial Intelligence (AI):

- Technology that creates realistic text, images, and videos

Misinformation Vs. Disinformation:

- Misinformation = false info (no intent)
- Disinformation = intentionally misleading

Why it matters:

- AI makes fake content easier, faster, and more believable.
- Social media spreads it at a large scale

AI Content:

- Deepfakes and synthetic media are hard to detect

Impact:

- Users struggle to identify fake content
- Influences opinions, especially politics

Issues

- Difficulty distinguishing real vs. AI-generated content
- Spread of misinformation at scale and speed
- Low digital/media literacy among users
- Unreliable AI detection tools
- Algorithmic Biases
- Stakeholders: citizens, politicians, companies, third parties / foreign agents

Real – World Example

- Pentagon Explosion Deepfake (2023)
- AI-Generated image falsely showed an explosion near the Pentagon.
- Went viral and was believed by many users
- Impact: Caused a temporary drop in the stock market and panicked Americans

Relevant Facts

62% Can distinguish
AI images

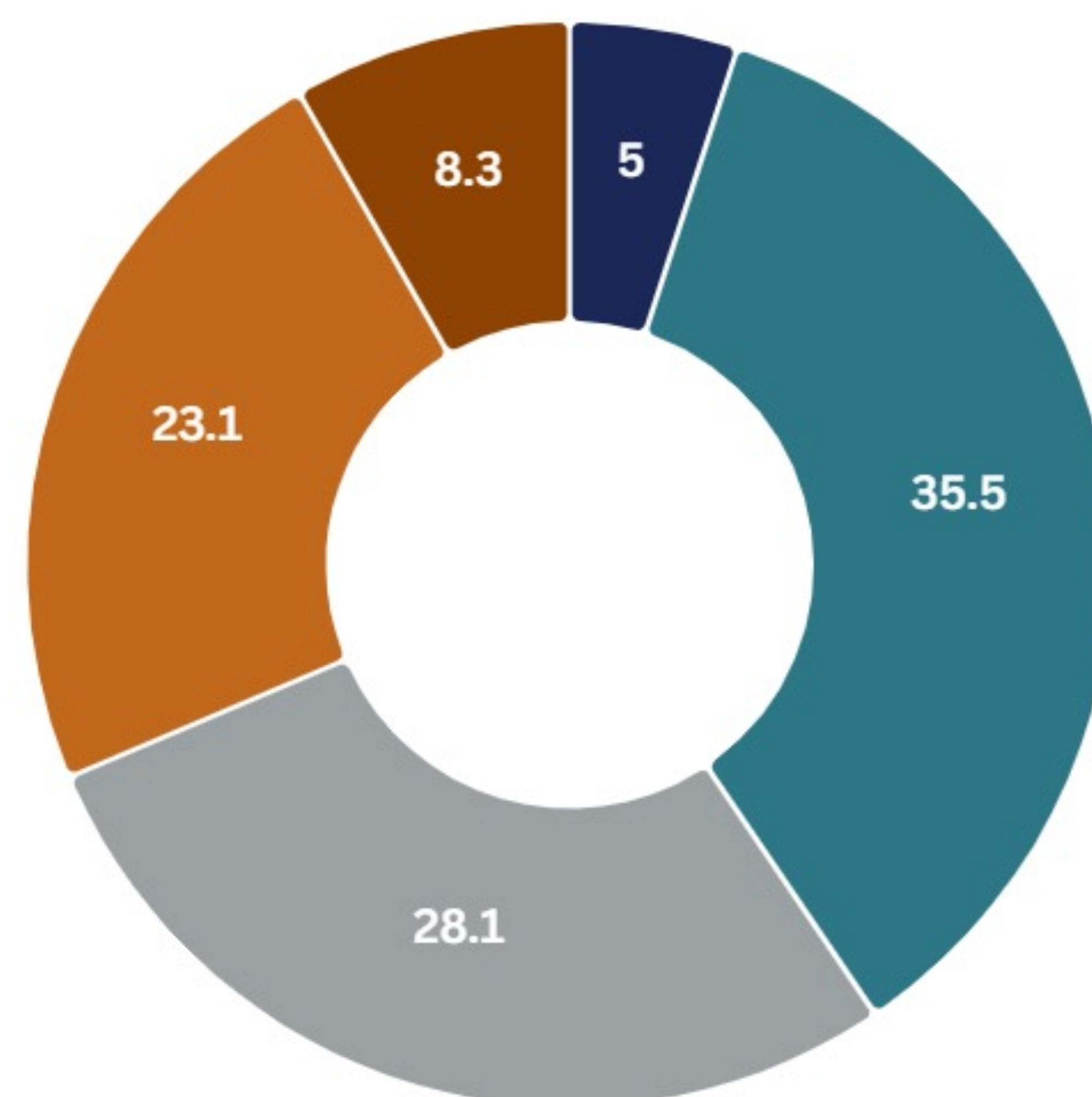
42% Know what
deepfakes are

60% Under 30 24% Over 64

Effect of Political Affiliation on Content Validity in Pakistan

Source: An Investigation into the role of AI in Forming Political Polarization and Misinformation in Pakistan

■ Highly Agree ■ Agree ■ Neutral ■ Disagree
■ Strongly Disagree



"40.5% population agreed that their political affiliations make them believe in AI-generated content whether it is authentic or not."

Courses of Action

Technological Interventions

- Detection tools to identify deepfakes and manipulated images
- Digital watermarking to verify a media file's origin
- Redesign platform algorithms to reduce echo chambers and prioritize credible content

Policy and Regulation

- Enact laws holding creators of malicious AI content legally accountable
- Require platforms to label AI-generated content and improve moderation transparency

Platform and Industry Collaboration

- Standardized moderation policies across platforms
- Build partnerships between platforms and independent fact-checkers

Education and User Empowerment

- Launch public digital literacy campaigns to build critical thinking skills
- Integrate design features on platforms to encourage responsible user behavior

Implications of Action

- Defining what is "harmful" or "false" content is subjective
- Detection systems can misclassify legitimate content, leading to over-censorship
- Automated tools may reflect algorithmic bias, disproportionately affecting certain communities
- Laws targeting misinformation risk expanding government control over speech and expression
- Surveillance-based detection methods risk serious privacy violations
- Lack of clear standards makes enforcement inconsistent across platforms

References

